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TITLE

Management-Related Discourse on r/antiwork, 2021-2025: An Exploratory Topic Modeling Study

SHORTENED TITLE

Management-Related r/antiwork Discourse

ABSTRACT

This exploratory study examines management-related discussion in r/antiwork across four rolling years, from March 2021 through February 2025. The archive collection returned 577,190 public r/antiwork submission records across 48 monthly pulls; 97,254 unique posts matched the established management-term filter and were analyzed with a BERTopic pipeline using sentence-transformer embeddings, UMAP, HDBSCAN, and class-based TF-IDF topic representations. The full-corpus model assigned 38.6% of posts to 199 non-outlier clusters. A documented codebook grouped 27 clusters into nine candidate themes, covering 18,506 posts (19.0% of the filtered corpus). Descriptive prevalence patterns show an early concentration of health, safety, and attendance discussion that declines over time, alongside a later rise in scheduling and time-off discussion. Compensation, career precarity, and recruitment remain present throughout the period. Findings are descriptive within the mapped subset and do not estimate sentiment, causal effects, or the full r/antiwork conversation.

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3,370 (main text; references, table, and figure captions excluded)

Management-Related Discourse on r/antiwork, 2021-2025: An Exploratory Topic Modeling Study

The Great Resignation refers to a period of record-setting employee turnover in the United States beginning in spring 2021 (Sull et al., 2022a). Implicated causes have ranged from mental health considerations like burnout to frustration with organizational culture and leadership (Ducharme, 2021; Cornish, 2021). However, much of this speculation has occurred in popular press articles rather than in scientific journals. One exception is Sull et al. (2022a), who found in his investigation of Glassdoor reviews that toxic work culture was the most effective predictor of a company's attrition rate from over 170 topics, with management practices being a leading contributor to such toxicity (Sull et al., 2022b).

This paper approaches the study of employee discontent in the Great Resignation through the lens of management-related public discourse. Building on earlier work that examined r/antiwork during the first year of the Great Resignation, the present study uses four years of posts to describe candidate themes in management-related discussion. Social media posts provide a large and naturally occurring text source, but they do not reveal individual motives for turnover or provide a representative sample of employees. Accordingly, this study treats observed topic patterns as exploratory signals rather than evidence of the causes of resignation or retention.

Background

Text Analysis in Psychology Research

Text analysis can support exploratory research by identifying patterns in how people discuss a topic without requiring categories to be fixed in advance (Grimmer & Stewart, 2013; Schwartz & Ungar, 2015). Contemporary topic-modeling workflows can combine contextual sentence embeddings with dimensionality reduction, density-based clustering, and topic

representations to generate inspectable candidate themes. In this study, we use that approach to describe management-related r/antiwork discourse over four rolling years while preserving explicit limits on coverage and interpretation.

The Great Resignation and Antiwork

“The Great Resignation” refers to a period of significant worker discontent beginning in spring 2021 (Fontinelle, 2022). As vaccination rates increased and COVID-19 restrictions eased, the U.S. saw a consequent increase in job openings. In the first six months of the Great Resignation, a record-setting 24 million American workers left their jobs (Sull et al., 2022a), representing at least 2.5% of the workforce each month (Ducharme, 2021). These turnover rates exceeded the prior record-setting levels of 2019 by 10-15% (Ducharme, 2021). By the end of 2021, over 20% of the workforce had turned over, estimated to cost American organizations more than a trillion dollars (McFeely & Wigert, 2019).

Concomitantly, an online community related to discontent with the modern conceptualization of work exploded in activity. r/antiwork is a subreddit, or a community within the social media site Reddit, that was originally dedicated to ending the concept of work but evolved into a discussion forum related to ending worker exploitation by managers and corporations (Harwell, 2021; TeiaRabishu, 2022). As such, r/antiwork serves as an abbreviation for “antiworking yourself to death” (Weeldreyer, 2021) and became the “Poster Child for The Great Resignation” (Reddit Staff, 2021). During this time, the subreddit grew from about 175,000 members with low activity in late 2020 to over 1 million members with high activity at the end of 2021 (Ehrlich, 2021; Reddit Staff, 2021). As such, this subreddit is an appropriate study sample to further our understanding of the Great Resignation.

Management and Turnover in the Great Resignation

One empirical study has investigated predictors of turnover during the Great Resignation, using text analysis to do so. Sull et al. (2022a) analyzed 1.3 million Glassdoor reviews from employees who left 500 large American firms in the first six months of the Great Resignation. They found that an employee mentioning toxic work culture was the most effective predictor of a company's attrition rate from over 170 topics. Toxic work culture was nearly 3 times more effective than the next-most useful predictor (job insecurity and reorganization) and 10 times more effective in predicting attrition than compensation (ranked 16th amongst the 170 topics). The authors found in a separate study that multiple of the leading contributors to toxic work culture directly relate to management practices, such as noninclusivity, disrespect, unethical behavior, and abusive management (Sull et al., 2022b). In particular, complaints of favoritism from managers, dishonesty and false promises, unsafe work conditions perpetuated by the employer, and verbal abuse, condescension, shouting, and bullying from managers inflated reports of toxic work culture.

However, while neither blue nor white collar industries appeared immune to turnover, certain organizations fared better than others, even within the same industry. For example, workers left Tesla at almost four times the rate they left Ford, and employees left JetBlue at double the rate they left Southwest Airlines (Sull et al., 2022a). These findings suggest that there are organizational and managerial practices that can maintain a happy, satisfied workforce. We hope to uncover some of these best practices through this study.

Insights from Leadership Theory

Leader-Member Exchange (LMX) Theory focuses on the relationship between leader and follower (Lord et al., 2016). The foundations of LMX theory are rooted in role theory, suggesting that subordinates' task performance and managers' reciprocal resource provision

depends on the type of their relationship, as well as in social exchange theory, lending the notion that material and nonmaterial resources can be exchanged. Relationships that are marked by “mutual trust, respect, liking and reciprocal influence” are described as “high LMX” and are associated with lower turnover than those “based strictly on employment contracts” called “low LMX” (Liden & Maslyn, 1998).

Good leaders, and therefore good managers, commit resources to their relationship with their subordinates (Lord et al., 2016). Flexibility, autonomy, and respect are nonmaterial resources that employees desire from their leaders. This assertion aligns with the finding that abusive management practices like bullying, cronyism, and shouting at employees predicted turnover in the Great Resignation (Sull et al., 2022a). Regarding specific tasks, employees mainly expect that a (good) leader takes care of group needs that are being neglected (Burke et al., 2007). Therefore, employees may find fault in their managers for experiences of burnout, especially in cases common to the pandemic in which layoffs precipitated greater workloads that exacerbated burnout (Sull et al., 2022a). Context also plays a large role in shaping perceptions of leaders (Lord et al., 2016), where particular behaviors are more desired in certain circumstances like crisis situations. However, little research exists on effective management practices during crisis situations (Eichenauer et al., 2022), like the COVID-19 pandemic, and much of leadership research has focused on stable rather than contextual influences of leadership (Lord et al., 2016).

The Current Study

The present study extends the original one-year exploration of management-related r/antiwork discourse into a four-year descriptive analysis. Rather than treating the earlier six-topic LDA solution as a model to reproduce, we use an embedding-based topic-modeling pipeline to identify candidate themes in title-plus-body text and to describe how their prevalence

changes across four rolling March-to-February windows. The earlier study provides historical context; the present analysis is designed to identify bounded, reproducible patterns in the documented theme map.

Research Question: Across management-related r/antiwork posts from March 2021 through February 2025, what candidate themes are identifiable in an exploratory BERTopic map, and how do their descriptive prevalence patterns vary across four rolling yearly windows?

Method

Corpus and Sampling

The Arctic Shift archive collection returned 577,190 public r/antiwork submission records across 48 monthly pulls dated from March 2021 through February 2025. We then analyzed 97,254 unique posts that matched the study's existing management-related filter (boss, manager, supervisor, or team lead variants). The frozen input and preprocessed corpus contained identical post-id sets, and every retained post re-matched the filter. The analytic text combined title and body after placeholder handling; posts with deleted or removed content were retained when usable title or body text remained. The corpus is a filtered public-discourse sample, not a representative sample of workers or a measure of individual employee attitudes.

Data Preparation and Time Windows

The primary representation was title-plus-body text. Four contiguous rolling windows were defined as Y1 (March 2021-February 2022), Y2 (March 2022-February 2023), Y3 (March 2023-February 2024), and Y4 (March 2024-February 2025). Candidate-theme prevalence was calculated as the number of posts assigned to the included theme clusters divided by every

filtered post in the same window. Thus, reported values describe the mapped subset of the filtered corpus rather than all potentially relevant management discussion.

Topic Modeling and Codebook

We fit a full-corpus BERTopic model using all-MiniLM-L6-v2 sentence-transformer embeddings, UMAP dimensionality reduction, HDBSCAN density-based clustering, and class-based TF-IDF topic representations (Grootendorst, 2022; McInnes et al., 2017, 2018; Reimers & Gurevych, 2019). The model produced 199 non-outlier clusters and assigned 37,536 posts (38.6% of the corpus) to those clusters. We reviewed the 30 largest clusters and documented a 27-cluster, nine-theme candidate codebook; generic, deleted, and community-meta clusters were excluded. The included clusters contain 18,506 posts, or 19.0% of all filtered posts and 49.3% of assigned posts.

We treated the theme map as exploratory and tested the boundaries of that interpretation. A frozen-corpus audit confirmed matching post ids and the management-term filter. Three UMAP seeds on the same 10,000-post stratified sample produced all-document adjusted Rand indices of 0.721 to 0.770 and joint-inlier indices of 0.900 to 0.966. A titles-only sensitivity analysis produced a materially different partition, so title-plus-body remains the primary representation. Cross-window term alignment is reported as supporting context only. We do not report sentiment results or causal inferences.

Results

The model's coverage is central to interpreting the results. Of 97,254 filtered posts, 37,536 (38.6%) received non-outlier cluster assignments; the finalized nine-theme codebook covers 18,506 posts (19.0% of all filtered posts). Assignment coverage varied from 33.1% to 44.0% by month (Figure 1). HDBSCAN outliers are therefore treated as a coverage limitation

rather than a substantive category. Table 1 reports candidate-theme prevalence by rolling window using all filtered posts in each window as the denominator.

Within the mapped subset, health, safety, and attendance discussion declined from 4.97% of Y1 posts to 2.50% in Y4, reflecting an early concentration of COVID- and illness-related clusters. Scheduling, hours, and time-off discussion increased from 1.71% to 3.20% and was the largest mapped theme in Y4. Workplace authority and interpersonal conflict also increased from 0.74% to 2.06%. Compensation and pay rights remained substantial in all windows, while career precarity and exit remained broadly stable. These are descriptive changes in the documented candidate-theme map, not evidence that the full r/antiwork conversation or workers' underlying experiences changed by the same amount.

Discussion

The updated analysis supports a narrower conclusion than the original one-year LDA account: management-related r/antiwork discussion changed in composition across the four rolling windows within a limited, auditable theme map. The early prominence of health, safety, and attendance content is consistent with the timing of COVID- and illness-related discussion, whereas the later prominence of scheduling and time-off clusters points to a different set of recurring concerns. The study does not establish why these patterns changed or whether they generalize beyond the sampled forum.

Compensation, career precarity and exit, and recruitment-related discussion remain visible across the observation period. That persistence should be read as evidence that these themes continue to appear in the mapped subset, not as a claim that any concern is universally salient or unchanged in the broader labor force. Similarly, the increase in workplace authority

and interpersonal-conflict clusters provides a candidate pattern for future investigation rather than a population estimate.

The results are most useful as a longitudinal descriptive extension of the earlier study. They show that a modern semantic topic-modeling workflow can separate candidate streams such as scheduling and time off, health and attendance, compensation, career precarity, workplace authority, collective power, and service work. The codebook, coverage metrics, and sensitivity results make those interpretations inspectable, but they do not turn the clusters into a final taxonomy or validate individual post labels as ground truth.

Practical Implications

The findings should be used as a source of questions for organizational listening and research, not as direct policy prescriptions. The recurring visibility of scheduling, time-off, compensation, and workplace-control discussion suggests that these are useful domains to examine with representative employee data and context-specific measures. Organizations should not infer turnover effects, employee sentiment, or causal priorities from this public-discourse analysis alone.

Strengths, Limitations, and Future Research

The study combines a four-year frozen corpus, document-level assignments, a documented codebook, explicit denominators, and completed robustness checks. Key limitations are the 61.4% HDBSCAN outlier rate, 19.0% theme-map coverage, 1.2% residual duplicate text, title-only sensitivity, and the management-related sampling frame. Future work could extend the

codebook or test a saved-model sensitivity analysis; neither sentiment nor causal claims are part of this exploratory paper.

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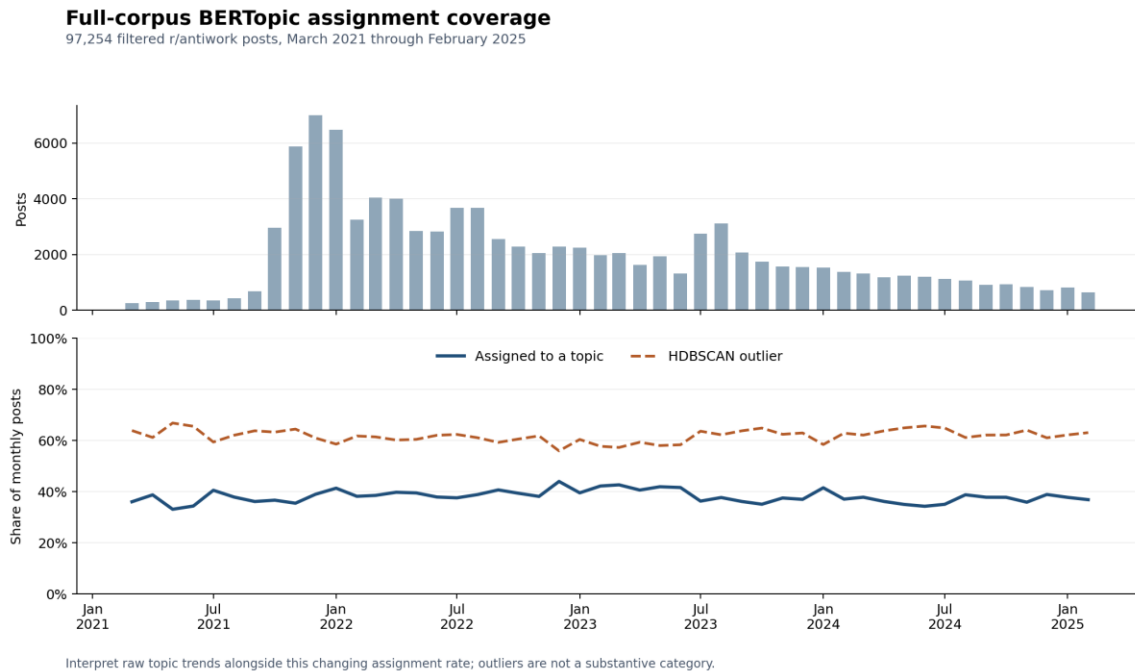
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Table 1**Candidate Theme Prevalence by Rolling Window**

Candidate theme	Y1	Y4	Change	Descriptive pattern
Health, safety, and attendance	4.97%	2.50%	-2.47 pp	Early COVID- and illness-related concentration contracts.
Scheduling, hours, and time off	1.71%	3.20%	+1.49 pp	Increases across the windows; largest mapped theme in Y4.
Workplace authority and interpersonal conflict	0.74%	2.06%	+1.32 pp	Increases in the mapped conflict and performance-review clusters.
Compensation and pay rights	3.52%	3.04%	-0.48 pp	Remains substantial in every window after a Y2 high.
Career precarity and exit	2.54%	2.47%	-0.07 pp	Broadly stable across the four windows.
Recruitment and labor market	1.98%	2.33%	+0.35 pp	Persistent with a modest net increase.
Work arrangements and control	1.01%	1.35%	+0.34 pp	Remains present; remote/RTO is a distinct stream.
Collective worker power and rights	0.82%	0.42%	-0.40 pp	Declines after the earlier unionization peak in the mapped subset.
Service work and tips	1.32%	0.93%	-0.39 pp	Declines in the mapped subset; codebook notes lexical noise.

Figure 1

Monthly BERTopic assignment coverage. Outliers are a coverage limitation, not a substantive category.

**Figure 2**

Candidate-theme prevalence by rolling window. Shares use all filtered posts in each window as the denominator.

Provisional theme prevalence by rolling window

Share of all filtered posts; rolling-window denominators are shown in the legend. Exploratory 27-cluster map excludes generic, deleted, and community-meta clusters.

